

POU11011: Introduction to Political Science

Lecture 1 (Teaching Week 2): Welcome + Is this politics?

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Tuesday 22 September 2026

Is *this* politics?

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Which of these is politics?

- **Rent freeze.** A government caps what landlords can charge. Confiscation, or addressing inequalities?
- **Family row.** Sunday dinner, and somebody brings up the Occupied Territories Bill. Voices are raised, even though no one is in politics.
- **Waiting list.** Somebody decides whether the 70-year-old's hip comes before the 40-year-old's. They are not elected, and they do it every week.
- **Nurses' strike.** They walk out, appointments are cancelled, and somebody has to decide who wins.
- **Street protest turns violent.** Hundreds of people take to the streets over an issue they care about, things get out of hand.
- **Coup d'état.** Soldiers surround parliament. By morning there's a new government and nobody voted for it.

What do these have in common?

- Somebody wants something somebody else doesn't want to give
- There isn't enough of it to go around: money, respect, land, power, the right to be listened to
- Eventually, *some* outcome happens. A decision gets made, even if that decision is “nothing changes.”

This is the core of politics: **conflict, plus collective decision-making, under scarcity.**

A working definition

Politics: *the process by which people decide, collectively, how to handle the things they disagree about: who gets what, who's bound by the outcome, and whether that outcome sticks.*

Notice what's *not* in that definition: parliaments, elections, politicians. Those are one place politics happens. They are not the only place!

Four ways people have defined it

Political scientists have argued about this for a while. Roughly:

- **The art of government** — cabinet rooms and parliaments. The narrowest definition.
- **Public affairs** — the public sphere, but nothing behind a front door.
- Compromise and consensus: a *method* of settling disagreement by negotiation rather than force.
- Power: anywhere one person or group gets another to do something they wouldn't otherwise do. The broadest definition.



Why bother defining it at all?

Because how you draw the line decides what counts as a *political* problem and what gets waved away as “just personal,” “just private,” “just the market.”

Politics is tough

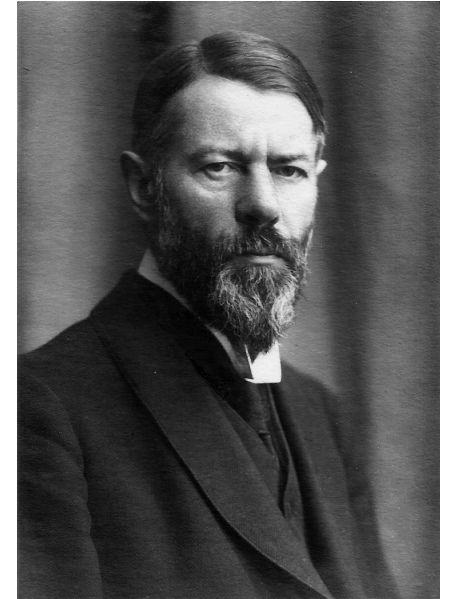
“Politics [is] the activity by which differing interests within a given unit of rule are conciliated by giving them a share in power...”

— Bernard Crick, In Defence of Politics (1962)

Politics is messy, slow, compromising, beats the alternatives.

“Politics is a strong and slow boring of hard boards. It takes both passion and perspective.”

— Max Weber, Politics as a Vocation (1919)



The kicker

- Politics is **how societies solve problems** they can't solve by force or by unanimous agreement — which is most problems.
- Every case today was politics working (or straining, or breaking). None of them were an aberration.

That's the argument this module is built on. Everything from here is “so, how does that actually work?”

A photograph of a protest scene. In the foreground, the heads and harnesses of several police horses are visible. Behind them, a line of police officers in riot gear stands. A large crowd of people is gathered on the street, some holding signs. One sign reads "OCCUPATION TO NO EDUCATION REQUIRED". Another sign says "FULLY NOW". A person in the foreground is holding a Canon camera. The background shows city buildings.

So what's this module actually about?

Three questions before reading week...

1. **Where do states come from and why can some of them actually run a country while others can't?**
2. **What are people on the left and the right actually arguing about?**
3. **Why do some identities become battle lines, and most never do?**

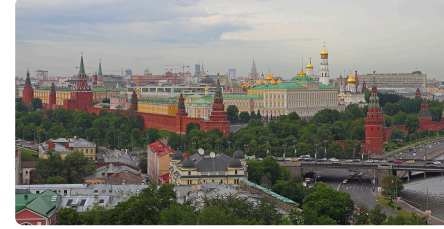
...and three after it

4. **Democracy or dictatorship and would you notice the moment one turned into the other?**
5. **Who can stop whom?** Constitutions, parliaments, planning objectors: who actually holds a veto?
6. **How do we know any of this is true** and how do political scientists get fooled?

Politics vs political *science*

- **Systematic comparison**
- **Weighing evidence across cases**
- **“How do we know that?”**

Who am I?



- From Minneapolis, Minnesota.
- Lived in New York, Abu Dhabi, and Moscow before Dublin.
- My own research: Russian politics, authoritarianism, corruption.
- When and why Russian mayors get arrested
- Why some autocracies are more corrupt than others?
- How ordinary people decide whether to protest a repressive regime
- On what basis do political parties compete for votes...when the election is rigged?

How this module works

- Two 50-minute lectures per week: Tuesdays 11am (B101), Fridays 1pm (Goldsmith)
- Four fortnightly tutorials across the term, led by TAs
- Readings: Heywood & Laing, *Politics*, 6th edition (2025).

How you'll be assessed

- **10% — tutorial discussion points.** A short written submission before each of the four tutorials, plus attendance at all four.
- **30% — a short assignment.** An 800-word blog post applying a course concept to a live political event. Due **Friday 23 October, 23:59**.
- **60% — a final essay.** 1,500 words, your choice from a set of questions. Due **Tuesday 15 December, 23:59**.

Next up

Your job: do the readings, come to lectures, engage in your tutorials

Read: Heywood & Laing, *Politics*, Chapter 1

On Blackboard and the module webpage after class: these slides, the syllabus, the readings/textbook.

Think about this: who has power over your daily life that you have *never once watched them exercise*?

See you Friday

See you Friday

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Slides and readings: noahbuckley.me/teaching/pou11011-mt2026

Reading for next time is on the module page and Blackboard.